

Technical Hiring Playbook

A Guide to Hiring Engineers at Early-Stage Startups

Table of Contents

1. [Hiring Philosophy](#)
 2. [Defining the Role](#)
 3. [Sourcing Candidates](#)
 4. [The Interview Process](#)
 5. [Technical Assessment](#)
 6. [Making the Offer](#)
 7. [Onboarding](#)
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1. Hiring Philosophy

The Startup Hiring Mindset

Hiring at a startup is fundamentally different from hiring at a large company. At an early-stage startup, every hire has an outsized impact on culture, velocity, and outcomes. A single great engineer can be worth 10 average ones, while a single bad hire can derail an entire team.

The goal is not to find candidates who check every box on a job description. Instead, you're looking for people who can grow with the company, adapt to changing requirements, and contribute beyond their defined role. Technical skills matter, but so do communication, ownership, and the ability to thrive in ambiguity.

What to Look For

The Three Pillars:

Pillar	What It Means	How to Assess
Smart	Learns quickly, thinks clearly	Problem-solving, past learning
Gets Things Done	Ships, iterates, delivers	Track record, work samples
Good Human	Collaborative, honest, kind	References, interactions

Early Hires vs. Later Hires

Your first 10 engineers set the technical and cultural foundation. These hires should be generalists who can wear multiple hats, make decisions with incomplete information, and build systems from scratch. They need high tolerance for ambiguity and strong ownership mentality.

As you scale past 20-30 engineers, you can hire more specialists. At this stage, you need people who excel in specific domains and can go deep on particular problems. The bar for generalist skills can be slightly lower, but domain expertise becomes more important.

2. Defining the Role

Writing the Job Description

A good job description attracts the right candidates and filters out the wrong ones. It should be honest about what the role entails, what the company offers, and what you're looking for.

Structure:

1. **Hook:** Why this role matters and why your company is exciting
2. **About Us:** What you do, your stage, your mission
3. **The Role:** What they'll actually do day-to-day

- 4. **Requirements:** Must-haves (keep this short)
- 5. **Nice-to-Haves:** Bonus skills (be honest)
- 6. **What We Offer:** Compensation, equity, benefits, culture

Common Mistakes:

- Listing every technology ever invented as “required”
- Requiring 5+ years for a junior role
- Being vague about compensation
- Writing a boring, corporate-sounding description

Leveling Framework

Level	Title	Experience	Scope
L1	Junior Engineer	0-2 years	Tasks within features
L2	Engineer	2-4 years	Features end-to-end
L3	Senior Engineer	4-7 years	Projects, mentoring
L4	Staff Engineer	7+ years	Systems, architecture
L5	Principal Engineer	10+ years	Company-wide impact

3. Sourcing Candidates

Sourcing Channels

Highest Quality:

- Referrals from your team
- Your personal network
- Investors’ networks
- Former colleagues

Good Quality:

- LinkedIn outreach (personalized)
- GitHub/Stack Overflow
- Tech communities (Discord, Slack)
- Meetups and conferences

Volume Plays:

- Job boards (LinkedIn, Indeed)
- AngelList/Wellfound
- Hacker News “Who’s Hiring”
- University recruiting

Writing Outreach Messages

Cold outreach works when it’s personalized and respectful. The best messages show you’ve done your homework on the candidate and explain why they specifically would be a good fit.

Template:

Subject: [**Specific** thing about their work] + [Your company]

Hi [Name],

I came across your [**specific** project/contribution] **and** was impressed **by** [**specific** detail]. I'm [Your Name], [role] at [Company].

We're building [**one** sentence about what you do] **and** looking **for** engineers who [**specific** quality they have].

Would you be **open to** a quick **call to** learn more? **No** pressure either way.

[Your Name]

Building a Talent Pipeline

Don't wait until you have an open role to start building relationships. The best candidates are often not actively looking, and it takes time to build trust. Engage with the community, share your work, and maintain relationships with talented people even when you're not hiring.

4. The Interview Process

Process Design

A good interview process is rigorous but respectful of candidates' time. It should assess what matters while providing a positive experience regardless of outcome.

Recommended Flow:

Stage	Duration	Purpose	Who
Recruiter Screen	30 min	Logistics, basics	Recruiter
Hiring Manager	45 min	Fit, experience	Manager
Technical Screen	60 min	Coding basics	Engineer
Onsite/Virtual	3-4 hours	Deep assessment	Team
Reference Checks	30 min × 2	Verification	Recruiter

Interview Questions

Experience Deep-Dive:

- “Tell me about a project you're proud of. What was your specific contribution?”
- “Describe a technical decision you made that you later regretted. What did you learn?”
- “How do you approach learning a new technology or domain?”

Problem-Solving:

- “Walk me through how you would design [relevant system].”
- “Here’s a bug report. How would you approach debugging it?”
- “We’re seeing [performance issue]. What would you investigate?”

Collaboration:

- “Tell me about a time you disagreed with a teammate. How did you resolve it?”
- “How do you prefer to receive feedback?”
- “Describe your ideal working relationship with product/design.”

Avoiding Bias

Interview bias is real and can cause you to miss great candidates or hire the wrong ones. Structured interviews with consistent questions and rubrics help reduce bias. Having diverse interviewers and focusing on demonstrated ability rather than credentials also helps.

5. Technical Assessment

Assessment Options

Method	Pros	Cons
Live Coding	Real-time thinking	Stressful, artificial
Take-Home	Realistic, less stress	Time-consuming
Pair Programming	Collaborative, realistic	Requires skilled interviewer
System Design	Tests architecture	Hard for junior candidates
Code Review	Tests real skill	Needs good sample code

Live Coding Best Practices

Live coding interviews are stressful for candidates. Your goal is to see how they think, not to trick them. Choose problems that are relevant to the work, allow multiple

approaches, and can be completed in the time allotted.

Good Problems:

- Have clear requirements
- Allow for discussion and iteration
- Test relevant skills
- Have multiple valid solutions

Bad Problems:

- Require obscure knowledge
- Have “gotcha” solutions
- Are too easy or too hard
- Don’t relate to the job

Take-Home Projects

Take-home projects give candidates time to do their best work without interview pressure. However, they require significant time investment, which can disadvantage candidates with families or other commitments.

Guidelines:

- Scope to 2-4 hours maximum
 - Provide clear requirements
 - Allow flexibility in approach
 - Pay for the time (seriously)
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6. Making the Offer

Compensation Philosophy

Early-stage startup compensation typically includes below-market salary offset by meaningful equity. As companies grow, cash compensation increases while equity

grants decrease. Be transparent about your philosophy and how compensation evolves.

Compensation Components

Component	Early Stage	Growth Stage
Base Salary	70-90% of market	90-100% of market
Equity	0.1-1%+	0.01-0.1%
Bonus	Rare	10-20% target
Benefits	Basic	Comprehensive

Equity Basics

Equity is a critical part of startup compensation, but many candidates don't understand it. Take time to explain how equity works, what it could be worth, and what the risks are.

Key Terms to Explain:

- Option pool and grant size
- Vesting schedule (typically 4 years, 1-year cliff)
- Exercise price and 409A valuation
- Dilution and what it means
- Exit scenarios and potential outcomes

Closing Candidates

The best candidates have multiple options. To close them, you need to sell the opportunity while being honest about the challenges. Understand what matters to them and address their concerns directly.

Closing Tactics:

- Move quickly once you've decided
- Have founders/executives involved

- Address concerns proactively
 - Create urgency without pressure
 - Be flexible on what matters to them
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7. Onboarding

The First Week

A great onboarding experience sets new hires up for success and reinforces that they made the right choice. The first week should focus on logistics, context, and relationships.

Day 1:

- Equipment and access setup
- Welcome from leadership
- Team introductions
- Lunch with the team

Days 2-3:

- Product and architecture overview
- Codebase walkthrough
- Development environment setup
- First small task

Days 4-5:

- Deeper technical sessions
- 1:1s with key stakeholders
- First meaningful contribution
- Week 1 check-in

The First 90 Days

The first 90 days should have clear milestones that build confidence and demonstrate impact. New hires should ship something meaningful within the first two weeks and take on increasing responsibility over time.

Period	Focus	Milestone
Week 1-2	Learn	Ship first PR
Week 3-4	Contribute	Own a small feature
Month 2	Build	Lead a project
Month 3	Impact	Measurable contribution

Buddy System

Pair new hires with an experienced team member who can answer questions, provide context, and help them navigate the organization. The buddy should be someone other than their manager to create a safe space for “dumb” questions.

Hiring Metrics

Track these metrics to improve your hiring process over time:

Metric	Target	Why It Matters
Time to Fill	30-60 days	Speed matters
Offer Accept Rate	70%+	Closing effectiveness
90-Day Retention	95%+	Hiring quality
Source Quality	Varies	Channel optimization
Candidate NPS	50+	Employer brand

Key Takeaways

Hiring is one of the most important things you do as a startup. Every hire shapes your culture, capabilities, and trajectory. Take it seriously, invest the time, and don't compromise on quality.

The best hiring processes are rigorous but humane. They assess what matters while respecting candidates' time and dignity. They're honest about the opportunity and the challenges.

Finally, remember that hiring doesn't end with the offer. Onboarding, development, and retention are just as important. The goal is not just to hire great people, but to help them do great work.

This playbook is provided by TechScoop for educational purposes.

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